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Los Angeles Times

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MONDAY, NOVEMBER 9, 2026

latimes.com



TOMAS OVALLE For The Times

"WE WANT a change," says Jorge Navarro, cutting Victor Salazar's hair at his shop in the San Joaquin Valley, where GOP Rep. David Valadao fell to a Democratic challenger by a margin that has left both parties stunned.

Democrats gear up for battles on immigration

Lawmakers want to increase oversight of agencies and rein in aggressive tactics.

BY ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — As it became clear on election day that Republicans would lose the House of Representatives, House Homeland Security Committee Democrats posted a three-word message on social media to Markwayne Mullin, who leads the agency: "clear your calendar."

The next day, Mullin posted a three-word message of his own: "Deportations will continue."

After affordability and the Iran war, immigration was a defining issue in the midterm elections, and now that Democrats have won majorities in the House and Senate, they plan to increase agency oversight and attempt to rein in the Trump administration's aggressive immigration enforcement policies.

Come January, Democrats will control every House seat along the U.S.-Mexico border. But while they will have wider leeway to investigate alleged wrongdoings of the last two years, how much they can advance their immigration agenda will likely depend on how much Republicans will collaborate with them. Any advances would also require the approval of President Trump, who on Friday appointed Stephen Miller, the architect of many of his administration's most stringent immigration policies, as his new chief of staff.

Democrats have already started outlining their goals

[See **Congress,** A5]

Congress to focus on healthcare

New majority is expected to move quickly to boost Medicaid and lower ACA costs. **NATION, A4**

New leaders on climate agenda

Two Californians poised to head House environmental and energy committees. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Political tide takes a turn in California's heartland

BY IAN JAMES AND NICOLE NIXON

DELANO, Calif. — While cutting men's hair in his barbershop, Jorge Navarro has been hearing the same concerns over and over: The prices of gas, food and housing are going up. Immigration agents are lurking outside stores and schools. And President Trump and the Republicans are to blame.

Widespread dissatisfaction with the decisions being made in Washington, he said, helped Democrat Randy Villegas trounce Republican incumbent David Valadao to take his congressional seat in Tuesday's election.

"We want a change," Navarro said, speaking in Spanish. "We hope for a change."

Villegas won in a region of the San Joaquin Valley that has been dominated by Republicans for two decades. The majority Latino district stretches from western Fresno to Bakersfield, an agricultural area with dairy farms, grapevines and vast orchards of almonds, pistachios and oranges.

That Valadao lost to Villegas, a community college professor who ran on a populist message, was not a major surprise, given the gains Democrats made nationwide. But Villegas' margin of victory left both Republican and Democratic leaders and operatives stunned. The progressive challenger has maintained a lead of roughly 30 percentage points since election night. Although votes still are being counted, the Associated Press has declared Villegas the winner.

"It was remarkable," said Christian Romo, chair of the Kern County Democratic Party. "I knew we would win but didn't expect this margin, and I didn't think that

[See **Heartland,** A5]

As kids strain to see, risks become clearer

Rise in myopia among children could turn into 'tidal wave' of eye disease and blindness.

BY CORINNE PURTILL

Neither she nor her husband needed glasses until middle age, so Cassia van der Hoof Holstein was a bit surprised to learn that her 8-year-old daughter, Viva, was struggling to see the board in class.

When Van der Hoof Holstein started reading about nearsightedness in children, that surprise turned into concern. Understanding of pediatric myopia had advanced dramatically since her own school years, when needing glasses seemed little more than an inconvenience.

Now modern life was straining the limits of human vision, at ever younger ages. More hours spent with screens close to our faces and fewer hours in natural light are changing the shape of our eyeballs, elongating the spheres from front to back.

As the years progress, the stretched eyeball weakens and falters: retinal tears, macular degeneration, cataracts and glaucoma. The sooner that process starts in a child's growing eye, the faster it progresses. Nearsighted kids such as Viva face a significantly higher lifetime risk of serious eye problems and potential blindness.

"Eyesight is so, so precious, and it's scary to think about that potentially being impacted," Van der Hoof Holstein said recently from her home in San Francisco.

Viva is hardly alone. Over

HOLLYWOOD IN CRISIS

Jersey rolls out red carpet

Garden State's film industry is booming, with aggressive tax credits drawing studio interest

By Meg James | REPORTING FROM WEST ORANGE, N.J.

America's film industry flickered to life in this state with a chip on its shoulder.

In 1888, inventor Thomas A. Edison began developing a motion picture camera at his West Orange laboratory. His crew built an odd-shaped soundstage — giving birth to moviemaking. But soon, New Jersey lost the action to flashier New York and, then, the industry famously moved west to sunny Los Angeles, where it prospered for a century.

But filmmakers are back in New Jersey, and production is booming again.

At a time when filming in Los Angeles has plunged to historic lows, New Jersey has soared, becoming one of the nation's hottest film destinations and squeezing into the limelight of its bigger neighbor across the Hudson River.

State leaders have rolled out the red carpet. They have adopted aggressive tax credits and awarded up to $387 million to Netflix to build a $1-billion studio complex at Ft. Monmouth, a former U.S. Army base near the Jersey Shore. More than 80 buildings have been bulldozed, and on a recent afternoon, towering yellow cranes dotted the loam as soundstages, mills and office space began to take shape.

Less than 10 years ago, total movie and TV production spending in New Jersey was a mere $67 million, according to the state's Economic Development Authority. By 2025, industry spending in the Garden State had reached $1.2 billion, as reported by production data firm ProdPro, behind only California, New York and Georgia.

Meanwhile, California's film spending declined 37% to $5.2 billion from 2021 to 2025.

Nearly three dozen major films and TV projects were produced in New Jersey in 2025, double the count of five years ago,

[See **New Jersey,** A8]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

TRAIN TRACKS in San Clemente are threatened by rising sea levels, strong storms and beach erosion.

Surf, sand and a rail rescue plan in O.C.

Coastal panel OKs permit to replenish beach, fortify tracks in San Clemente.

BY GRACE TOOHEY

A major sand replenishment is headed to the San Clemente beach along the long-imperiled railway line, part of a large shoreline work package aimed at fortifying the vulnerable railroad while also protecting the area's shrinking beaches.

The California Coastal Commission last week approved an extensive permit that railway officials hope will help maintain the critical rail line, which has faced an onslaught of rising seas, harsh waves and strong storms over the last several years that have led to repeated closures — an issue only intensified this year by the historic El Niño.

A key element of the permit is the placement of almost 700,000 cubic yards of sand on sections of the area's shrinking — or completely gone — beaches, an investment Orange County officials say will be the single largest sand replenishment along this stretch of coast in more than 60 years.

"This is the first step to resolving a half-century of inaction by our community," Orange County Supervisor Katrina Foley, who sits on the Orange County Transportation Authority's board of directors, said at Thursday's Coastal Commission hearing.

She admitted that the county has, for too long, fo-

[See **Railway,** A6]

Punjabi drivers trade big rigs for food trucks

There's been a surprise surge of Indian food spots along lonely stretches of Cal-

Sunday

Los Angeles Times

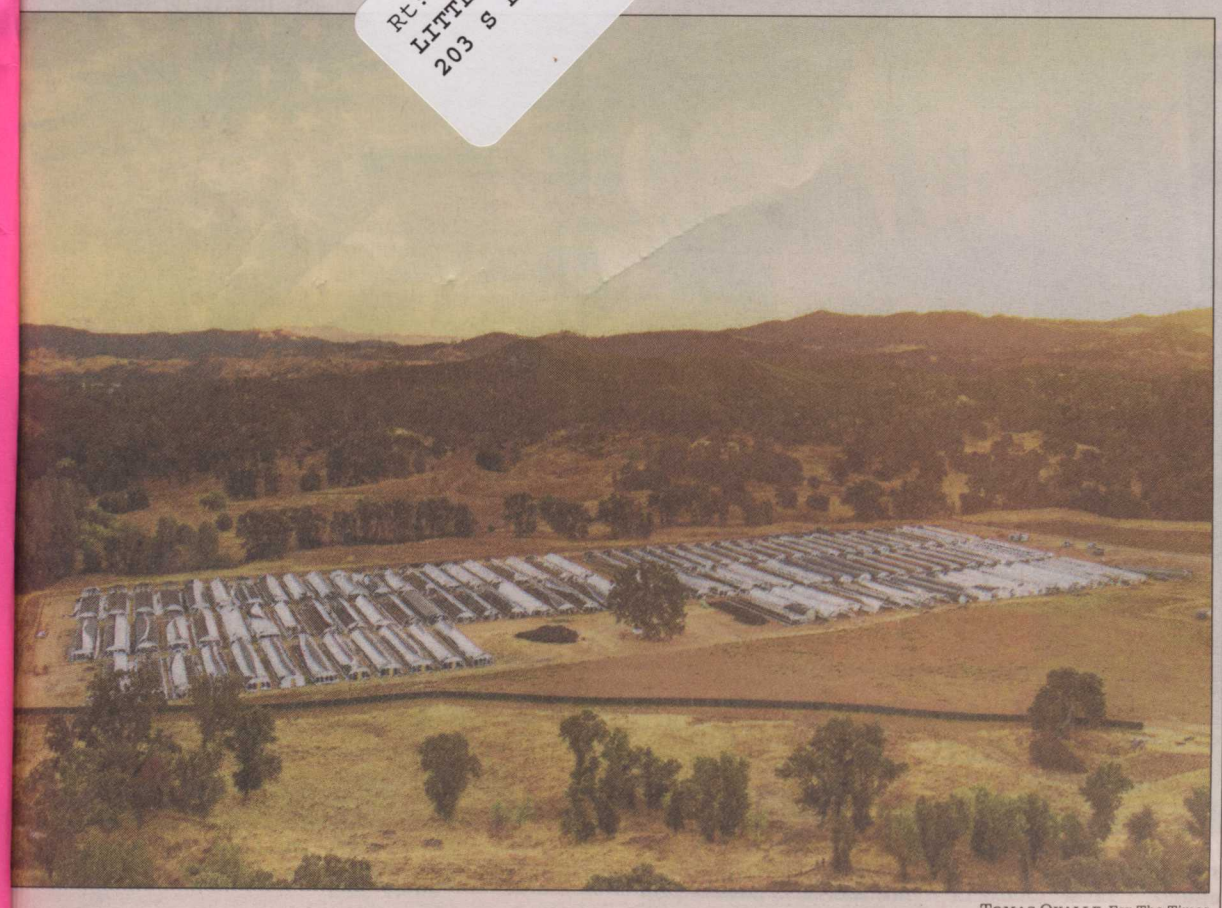
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TOMAS OVALLE For The Times

EVIDENCE of potentially hazardous chemicals was found at this cannabis operation in Lower Lake, Calif.

LEGAL WEED, BROKEN PROMISES

A losing quest for clean cannabis

California regulators fail to keep up with hazardous chemicals or crack down on the growers using them

BY PAIGE ST. JOHN

LOWER LAKE, Calif. — Two years after The Times found that cannabis sold at California dispensaries contained alarming levels of pesticides, the safety of the state's legal weed remains a crapshoot, as government regulators fail to keep up with an ever-evolving slate of hazardous chemicals or crack down on the growers using them.

A new round of tests commissioned by The Times shows that even as many major cannabis brands have cleaned up their products, others are using pesticides off the state's radar.

Brands, including Stiiizy and West Coast Cure, that were contaminated two years ago came up largely clean in the latest testing — a change that industry leaders attribute to pressure from consumers outraged by The Times' 2024 reporting.

But three other brands, all from the same manufacturer, contained significant quantities of a pesticide, pymetrozine, that was widespread in the 2024 testing. And previously unseen chemicals hazardous to human health were detected in a quarter of the 49 inhalable products tested by The Times.

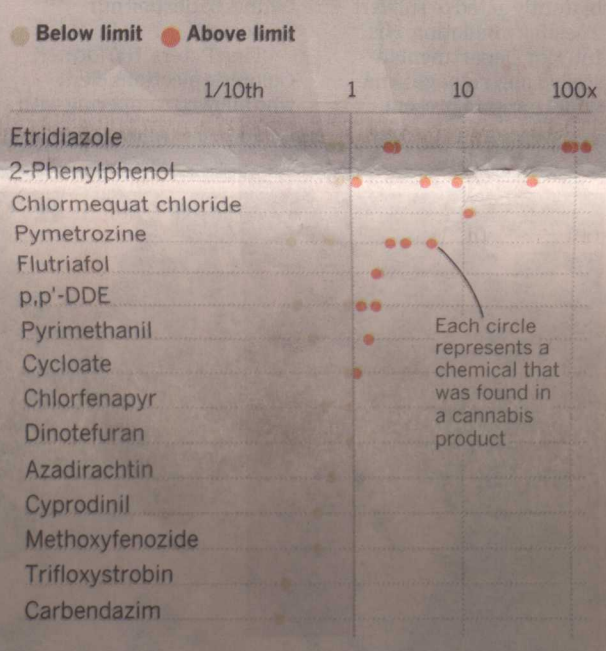
One product contained the soil fungicide etridiazole, a likely carcinogen not widely known to cannabis safety professionals, in amounts 125 times higher than what would trigger safety testing under federal tobacco standards.

About 17% of Americans smoke cannabis products, including nearly a quarter of people under age 29, according to an August Gallup poll. When cannabis is inhaled — whether by vape, bong or joint — chemical contaminants travel directly from the lungs into the bloodstream and to the brain and internal organs. Even low levels can cause harm over time, contributing to nerve damage, brain cell death, genetic deformities, organ failure and cancers.

Eight years after legalization was sold to voters as a way to protect cannabis consumers, the weed supply is policed by an under-resourced state [See Weed, A8]

Pesticides found in legal weed

In tests of 49 legal cannabis products, independent labs found 31 toxic chemicals, eight of those at levels exceeding either state limits for cannabis or federal safety-testing thresholds for tobacco.



Sixteen pesticides found at low or trace amounts not charted: bifenazate, bifenthrin, biphenyl, buprofezin, chlordane, diphenylamine, fenazaquin, fluopyram, formetanate HCl, metalaxyl, myclobutanil, oxamyl, permethrin, piperonyl butoxide, propargite and tebuconazole.

For pesticides for which California has set no limit, the U.S. safety testing threshold for tobacco residues is used.

SEAN GREENE Los Angeles Times

Election sets up new hurdles for resuming war

Trump may be limited on Iran by divisions in his party and a sudden push to oust Hegseth.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Just days ago, a resumption of war with Iran appeared inevitable, regardless of the outcome of the midterm elections. U.S. diplomats urged their Arab counterparts to prepare for an intense period of fighting. Nonessential foreign service and intelligence personnel across the Middle East were ordered home, while senior officials at the Pentagon debated the strategic objectives renewed hostilities could realistically achieve, two U.S. officials told The Times.

Now, the sharpest electoral rebuke in half a century is forcing a reckoning for President Trump, who insisted the day after the vote that his war against Tehran was worth the political cost. Renewed strikes on Iran remain a distinct possibility, the officials said.

But a sudden bipartisan push to oust Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth over his handling of the conflict, coupled with a statement of brazen defiance from his own vice president, JD Vance, opposing the war, could constrain Trump's ability to resume the fight before Democrats take control of Congress next year.

A Republican lawmaker from Kentucky, Thomas Massie, plans to present impeachment articles against Hegseth this week over his role overseeing the war effort — a measure expected to gain enough support from Republicans to pass.

While maintaining public support for the Defense secretary, Trump has begun [See Iran, A7]

U.S. carries out strikes on Iran

President Trump says attack was "minor"; Qatar offers nuclear proposals. WORLD, A4

Raman's scrappy path to victory

How the challenger's campaign, launched at the deadline, toppled the incumbent mayor.

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

The first volunteers gathered in the back house of Nithya Raman's Silver Lake home with little besides a whiteboard counting down the number of days until the June 2 primary election.

Raman had jumped into the Los Angeles mayor's race the day before, right at the Feb. 7 filing deadline. Her campaign didn't have an office, a bank account, a campaign treasurer, or even a proper website.

It lacked, put simply, "the most basic things," said Ian Manheimer, Raman's campaign manager, who joined the team after a 10 p.m. call from Raman the night before the filing deadline. There would be a meeting the next day in Raman's backyard accessory dwelling unit to get things rolling.

"For anyone who suspected Nithya had designs on this for a long time, you could just come to the ADU and that would dispel those notions," Manheimer said.

Those unassuming beginnings in Raman's backyard, with her parents and her husband's parents taking turns cooking vegetarian Indian lunches for the small staff, evolved into a disciplined campaign that overcame initial struggles to unseat incumbent Mayor Karen Bass, a veteran politician who had racked up endorsements from most of L.A.'s traditional power brokers.

Raman did it on a hyper-abbreviated timeline by turning out and expanding her base of younger renters, pitching herself successfully to Latino voters, securing late but key endorsements from groups and officials that gave massive support [See Raman, A10]

Miller's rise stokes fears, and passion to fight

BY GRACE TOOHEY, SUHAUNA HUSSAIN AND KAREN GARCIA

President Trump's appointment of Stephen Miller — the architect of the administration's extreme

staff is sparking alarm among immigrant advocates and politicians across California.

But last week's sweeping Democratic victories are giving immigrant communities hope that control of Congress will provide them

Miller grew up in Santa Monica but has become a relentless critic of California, specifically its immigration policies, protections and, in many ways, identity. Southern California was the first city targeted by widespread immigration raids last year, upending the region in ways

particularly for immigrant communities.

Miller's promotion, announced Friday, is seen by many as an indication that the president has no intention of backing away from some of his most polarizing policies during his last two

Why Bass' pivotal allies turned on her

Mayor's campaign

homelessness, the city budget and finally, the Pali-



TOMAS OVALLE For The Times

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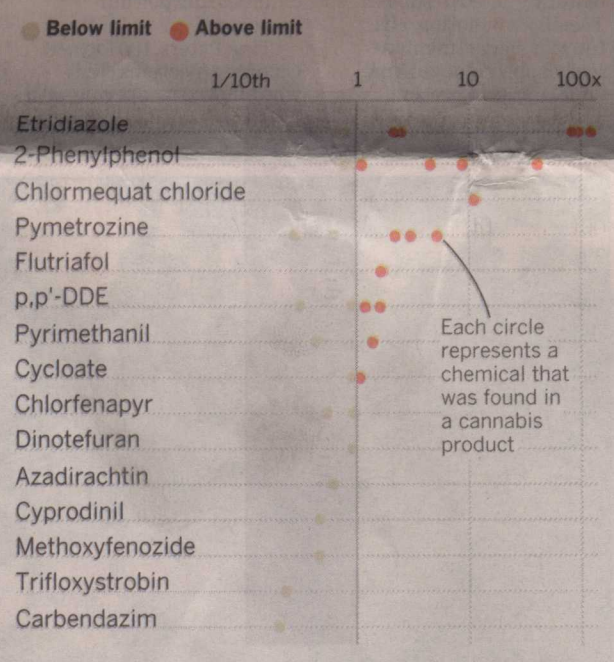
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SEAN GREENE Los Angeles Times

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Miller's rise stokes fears, and passion to fight

BY GRACE TOOHEY, SUHAUNA HUSSAIN AND KAREN GARCIA

President Trump's appointment of Stephen Miller — the architect of the administration's extreme crackdown on immigration — to White House chief of staff is sparking alarm among immigrant advocates and politicians across California.

But last week's sweeping Democratic victories are giving immigrant communities hope that control of Congress will provide them with more tools to fight Miller's policies.

Miller grew up in Santa Monica but has become a relentless critic of California, specifically its immigration policies, protections and, in many ways, identity. Southern California was the first city targeted by widespread immigration raids last year, upending the region in ways that continue to reverberate, particularly for immigrant communities.

Miller's promotion, announced Friday, is seen by many as an indication that the president has no intention of backing away from some of his most polarizing policies during his last two years in office, despite devas- [See **Reaction,** A7]

BOMBAST AWAY: Stephen Miller has promoted hard-line positions through abrasive rhetoric. **NATION, A6**

Why Bass' pivotal allies turned on her

Mayor's campaign touted her ability to build relationships, but several crumbled.

BY DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

It wasn't that long ago that campaign strategist Estevan Montemayor was an enthusiastic booster for Karen Bass.

During her first run for mayor in 2022, Montemayor was working with Communities United for Bass, a campaign committee that spent $6 million on television ads, text messages and other voter outreach efforts.

The 35-year-old political consultant took on another expensive outside campaign this year — this one to support Councilmember Nithya Raman and oppose Bass. Asked about the change in allegiances, he said he became disenchanted with the mayor over her handling of homelessness, the city budget and finally, the Palisades fire.

"That's when I came to realize on a personal level that she was not capable of serving in an executive role," Montemayor said.

Bass, a 22-year political veteran, spent much of her failed reelection campaign touting her ability to work with others. She locked down support from labor unions, business groups and immigration advocates. She frequently pointed out 14 members of the City Council lined up behind her and not for Raman, who won Tuesday's election and will be sworn in next month.

Yet some of Bass' political relationships disintegrated during her four-year term, at times in dramatic ways. Those key colleagues and supporters turned against her, then went on to help orchestrate her political demise.

Early on in Bass' term, Los Angeles County Super- [See **Bass,** A10]



In the spirit of giving

Need inspiration with the holiday season quickly approaching? Our annual Gift Guide has you covered. See *latimes.com/giftguide* and **SECTION T.**

Eisenkot tapped to build coalition

Israel's president gives Netanyahu's opponent the first opportunity to try to form a new government. **WORLD, A3**

Newsom assumes risk on clemency

Governor's decision to grant mass commutations sends a clear message to the nation. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

No. 8 UCLA gets a statement win

Coach Bob Chesney extends his electric start, improving to 9-0, in a 34-20 victory over Minnesota. **SPORTS, D1**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com.**

Weather
Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 88/62. **B8**

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From backyard ADU to mayor of Los Angeles

[**Raman,** from A1]
to her campaign's ground game and by running on a hopeful message about restoring city services against a deeply unpopular mayor.

From the moment she got into the race, there was an evident, yet narrow lane for the progressive, second-term council member to rise to the city's highest office, but it was far from clear that she would be able to make it through.

::

For much of the primary, Raman and her campaign were all alone. She had few endorsements, and almost none from elected officials.

Because of her late entry into the race and some past disagreements, she failed to secure the backing of the Los Angeles chapter of the Democratic Socialists of America for the June 2 primary, even though the left-wing organization endorsed her in both of her council campaigns.

Raman got almost no supportive outside spending in the primary, while millions of dollars were spent opposing her.

But Raman had made a name for herself on the City Council as an advocate for tenant rights, and her campaign focused on turning out L.A.'s legions of renters to secure enough of the vote to make the runoff.

She was still a largely unknown entity early on in the race, with 51% of likely voters in a March poll saying they didn't know enough about Raman to form an opinion of her.

On top of that, Raman was quickly upstaged by Spencer Pratt, the Republican former reality television personality, whose slash-and-burn campaign on social media attacking L.A.'s liberal political establishment dominated news coverage.

While Raman's camp hadn't initially worried too much about Pratt, thinking he and entrepreneur Adam Miller would split the more conservative vote in the city, it became clear as the primary went on that Pratt could emerge over Raman as the second candidate in the runoff.



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

NITHYA RAMAN and her husband, Vali Chandrasekaran, on election night.

To dent Pratt's appeal, the Raman campaign worked to brand him as the MAGA Republican in the nonpartisan race, knowing it would hurt his chances in a deep-blue city like Los Angeles. They chose to try out the line at the only televised mayoral debate.

Raman didn't miss her chance.

"This is a MAGA Republican's idea of what Los Angeles looks like," she said during the NBC4 debate on May 6, referring to Pratt's sometimes dystopian depiction of L.A. "This is really not the city that I love so much."

Though Raman's debate performance was widely panned — and Pratt's was praised — her team felt she had gotten the point across to Angelenos: With the unpopular Bass almost certain not to win the primary outright, the runoff could either be a contest between two progressive Democrats, or Bass versus a candidate whose views echoed those of President Trump.

That debate was a learning moment for Raman and her campaign.

"She's up against an extremely seasoned politician and a television star. She's just a normal person who hasn't been on stage like that," Manheimer said.

But defining Pratt as MAGA, the campaign believed, would pull some voters to Raman from lower-performing candidates on the left and in the middle with the hopes of keeping Pratt out of the runoff.

> 'She was really dogged that it was a campaign that was hopeful, not nasty and cynical. She wanted the campaign to be a love letter to L.A.'
>
> — TESSA WICK, Raman campaign communications director

Raman was able to eke out a win against Pratt in the primary, getting 29% of the vote compared to his 26%, with Bass taking first place at 34%.

::

The sole goal of the primary for Raman's campaign was, self-evidently, to make it out of the primary.

If her team could move on to the runoff, it would be able to reset — fundraising would restart, it could build a bigger team and it would have a longer runway to increase Raman's name recognition and build out her base.

While Bass dominated labor and elected official endorsements throughout the race, Raman began to pick up key supporters in the runoff.

In August, the Western States Regional Council of Carpenters endorsed her, sponsoring an independent expenditure group for her called Estamos con Nithya for Mayor 2026.

That was followed by the endorsement from the union Unite Here Local 11, a major player in city politics, which represents hospitality workers at airports and in hotels. Raman also got major endorsements in the runoff from City Controller Kenneth Mejia and L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath.

Mejia especially became a pit bull for Raman at events and on social media.

"Kenneth would call every day and say, 'Let me know what myths I can bust today,' " said Tessa Wick, the communications director for Raman's campaign.

"We didn't have time to feel particularly lonely in the primary, but once we saw what it felt like to have all these groups and people behind us, each press conference we would do was injecting more force into this movement we were building," Wick said.

Raman's bid also got a serious infusion of cash from Aaron Sosnick, a hedge fund manager and bike lane advocate who poured $8 million into two independent expenditure groups to support Raman, making him the single biggest spender in the mayoral campaign.

"He is a cyclist. He just wants to not die riding the streets in L.A.," said Michael Schneider, who runs Streets for All, a transportation advocacy group that ran one of the independent expenditure groups that Sosnick funded.

Raman also capitalized on a difficult summer for Bass, during which the mayor faced turnover on both her campaign and administration teams, unsheltered homelessness rose citywide (but crucially, went down sharply in Raman's City Council district) and a massive fire burned at a cold-storage food warehouse in Boyle Heights, sending noxious fumes into the heavily Latino, working-class neighborhood.

"Many Latinos saw themselves in the Boyle Heights residents," said Lauren Perez-Rangel, senior director of Latino outreach for the Raman campaign.

Bass had prevailed in more Latino neighborhoods than any other candidate in the primary. The Raman campaign worked to change that in the runoff, Perez-Rangel said, focusing especially on Latino voters. Raman brushed up on her Spanish and used it frequently at events.

The campaign also teamed up with Latino and Spanish-language content creators to spread Raman's message of affordability, building more housing and solving the homeless crisis. The result: Raman led Bass among Latino likely voters throughout the runoff campaign, according to polls by UC Berkeley IGS and the L.A. Times.

Despite that growing support, Bass and her allies' negative portrayal of Raman in attack ads had a... fect, as Raman's unfavor... ratings rose month ... month. They framed ... council member as too ... left, allowing homeless ... campments in front ... schools and failing to s... up for thousands of ... Council votes.

"It was a race to def... Nithya," said Jeff Millm... an advisor and spok... person for Raman's ca... paign. "Their strategy w... to tear down Nithya. Our j... was to make sure that pe... ple knew Nithya's strengt... and record of success as ... council member."

As the campaign drew ... a climax, Raman improve... as a candidate and came ... as more confident durin... the two runoff debates. He... team said she spent man... hours improving her debat... skills. "There was no secre... weapon, just a person reall... committed to practicing," ... said Wick.

Still, she opened herse... up to attacks from Bass' sid... during the final debate Oct... 13, after she said the cit... used to be the "gold stand... ard" of noncooperation with... immigration authorities ... under controversial former ... LAPD Chief Daryl Gates. ... Bass hammered Raman ... over the remark, accusing ... the council member of ro... manticizing Gates' tenure.

Despite that and other ... missteps during the closing ... days of the campaign, her ... team said it was Raman's in... sistence on running a largely ... positive campaign about an ... optimistic vision of L.A.'s fu... ture that pushed her over ... the finish line.

"She was really dogged ... that it was a campaign that ... was hopeful, not nasty and ... cynical. She wanted the ... campaign to be a love letter ... to L.A.," said Wick.

In her election night ... speech, still trailing Bass by ... a few percentage points that ... she would quickly make up, ... Raman spoke to that vision.

She called it a vision ... where the people who made ... L.A. extraordinary could af... ford to live in the city and ... where government is re... sponsive and takes respon... sibility.

"We believed that Ange... lenos were hungry for that ... city," she said. "And it turns ... out that we were right."

As Bass touted relationship skills, allies became critics

[**Bass,** from A1]
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MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

COUNTY Supervisor Lindsey Horvath, hugging Bass, endorsed Nithya Raman.

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Montemayor, who had worked on the pro-Bass committee in 2022, supervised the carpenters' campaign, spending nearly $12 ...

For seven years, "Boy ... Meets World" served as an ... lectronic babysitter for mil... ions of kids growing up in ... he 1990s.

Fans had no social media ... o analyze the budding teen ... omance between Topanga ... awrence and Cor... Matthews while the sitcom ... ired on ABC. Since 202... ast members Daniel... Fishel, Rider Strong and W... Friedle have done that wo... or them on their rewat... odcast "Pod Meets World" ... They break down every e... sode, quiz dozens of gu... stars and dig up backst... anecdotes.

From recurring ... member Adam Scott re... ing an awkward momen... set to the show's hairst... dishing on Topanga's tr... setting Season 4 haircut ... 30-year-old secrets reve... on "Pod Meets World" ... become steady fodder f... lebrity news websites.

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Angeles chapter of the Democratic Socialists of America for the June 2 primary, even though the left-wing organization endorsed her in both of her council campaigns.

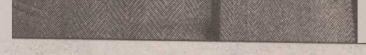
Raman got almost no supportive outside spending in the primary, while millions of dollars were spent opposing her.

But Raman had made a name for herself on the City Council as an advocate for tenant rights, and her campaign focused on turning out L.A.'s legions of renters to secure enough of the vote to make the runoff.

She was still a largely unknown entity early on in the race, with 51% of likely voters in a March poll saying they didn't know enough about Raman to form an opinion of her.

On top of that, Raman was quickly upstaged by Spencer Pratt, the Republican former reality television personality, whose slash-and-burn campaign on social media attacking L.A.'s liberal political establishment dominated news coverage.

While Raman's camp hadn't initially worried too much about Pratt, thinking he and entrepreneur Adam Miller would split the more conservative vote in the city, it became clear as the primary went on that Pratt could emerge over Raman as the second candidate in the runoff.



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

NITHYA RAMAN and her husband, Vali Chandrasekaran, on election night.

To dent Pratt's appeal, the Raman campaign worked to brand him as the MAGA Republican in the nonpartisan race, knowing it would hurt his chances in a deep-blue city like Los Angeles. They chose to try out the line at the only televised mayoral debate.

Raman didn't miss her chance.

"This is a MAGA Republican's idea of what Los Angeles looks like," she said during the NBC4 debate on May 6, referring to Pratt's sometimes dystopian depiction of L.A. "This is really not the city that I love so much."

Though Raman's debate performance was widely panned — and Pratt's was praised — her team felt she had gotten the point across to Angelenos: With the unpopular Bass almost certain not to win the primary outright, the runoff could either be a contest between two progressive Democrats, or Bass versus a candidate whose views echoed those of President Trump.

That debate was a learning moment for Raman and her campaign.

"She's up against an extremely seasoned politician and a television star. She's just a normal person who hasn't been on stage like that," Manheimer said.

> 'She was really dogged that it was a campaign that was hopeful, not nasty and cynical. She wanted the campaign to be a love letter to L.A.'
>
> — TESSA WICK, Raman campaign communications director

But defining Pratt as MAGA, the campaign believed, would pull some voters to Raman from lower-performing candidates on the left and in the middle with the hopes of keeping Pratt out of the runoff.

Raman was able to eke out a win against Pratt in the primary, getting 29% of the vote compared to his 26%, with Bass taking first place at 34%.

::

The sole goal of the primary for Raman's campaign was, self-evidently, to make it out of the primary.

If her team could move on to the runoff, it would be able to reset — fundraising would restart, it could build a bigger team and it would have a longer runway to increase Raman's name recognition and build out her base.

While Bass dominated labor and elected official endorsements throughout the race, Raman began to pick up key supporters in the runoff.

In August, the Western States Regional Council of Carpenters endorsed her, sponsoring an independent expenditure group for her called Estamos con Nithya for Mayor 2026.

That was followed by the endorsement from the union Unite Here Local 11, a major player in city politics, which represents hospitality workers at airports and in hotels. Raman also got major endorsements in the runoff from City Controller Kenneth Mejia and L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath.

Mejia especially became a pit bull for Raman at events and on social media.

"Kenneth would call every day and say, 'Let me know what myths I can bust today,' " said Tessa Wick, the communications director for Raman's campaign.

"We didn't have time to feel particularly lonely in the primary, but once we saw what it felt like to have all on a difficult summer for Bass, during which the mayor faced turnover on both her campaign and administration teams, unsheltered homelessness rose citywide (but crucially, went down sharply in Raman's City Council district) and a massive fire burned at a cold-storage food warehouse in Boyle Heights, sending noxious fumes into the heavily Latino, working-class neighborhood.

"Many Latinos saw themselves in the Boyle Heights residents," said Lauren Perez-Rangel, senior director of Latino outreach for the Raman campaign.

Bass had prevailed in more Latino neighborhoods than any other candidate in the primary. The Raman campaign worked to change that in the runoff, Perez-Rangel said, focusing especially on Latino voters. Raman brushed up on her Spanish and used it frequently at events.

The campaign also teamed up with Latino and Spanish-language content creators to spread Raman's message of affordability, building more housing and solving the homeless crisis. The result: Raman led Bass among Latino likely voters throughout the runoff campaign, according to polls by UC Berkeley IGS and the L.A. Times.

Despite that growing support, Bass and her allies' negative portrayal of Raman

hours improving her debate skills. "There was no secret weapon, just a person really committed to practicing," said Wick.

Still, she opened herself up to attacks from Bass' side during the final debate Oct. 13, after she said the city used to be the "gold standard" of noncooperation with immigration authorities under controversial former LAPD Chief Daryl Gates. Bass hammered Raman over the remark, accusing the council member of romanticizing Gates' tenure.

Despite that and other missteps during the closing days of the campaign, her team said it was Raman's insistence on running a largely positive campaign about an optimistic vision of L.A.'s future that pushed her over the finish line.

"She was really dogged that it was a campaign that was hopeful, not nasty and cynical. She wanted the campaign to be a love letter to L.A.," said Wick.

In her election night speech, still trailing Bass by a few percentage points that she would quickly make up, Raman spoke to that vision.

She called it a vision where the people who made L.A. extraordinary could afford to live in the city and where government is responsive and takes responsibility.

"We believed that Angelenos were hungry for that city," she said. "And it turns out that we were right."

As Bass touted relationship skills, allies became critics



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

COUNTY Supervisor Lindsey Horvath, hugging Bass, endorsed Nithya Raman.

[**Bass,** from A1]

visor Lindsey Horvath supported the mayor's work on homelessness and even introduced her at her State of the City address. But she eventually became one of Bass' fiercest critics and, behind the scenes, encouraged Raman to run. Horvath publicly endorsed Raman two weeks before the election.

The Western States Regional Council of Carpenters put nearly $2.3 million into efforts to elect Bass four years ago, producing TV ads and campaign signs promoting her. This time around, the group sponsored a committee that spent five times that amount in support of Raman, posting content on the website "Burned by Bass."

Then there's Raman herself. The council member supported many of the mayor's initiatives and campaigned with her while running for reelection in 2024. Even though she had endorsed Bass for mayor, she later launched her own last-minute mayoral bid, saying the city "can't seem to manage the basics."

Bass said she was blindsided.

"I didn't have any reason to see it coming," Bass replied when The Times asked about Raman's decision to challenge her. "Why would I see it coming if somebody has publicly endorsed me?"

Supporters of Bass say that in some ways, she actually broadened her coalition this time around, drawing support from individuals and organizations who opposed her in 2022, including real estate developer Rick Caruso, her onetime opponent, and the Los Angeles Police Protective League.

Assemblymember Mark Gonzalez (D-Los Angeles), who endorsed Bass and campaigned with her, said it's unfair to say that "because she lost a few friends, that that's why she lost the race."

"Losing the trust of her voters, that was the bigger loss," Gonzalez said. "Voters basically did not feel that they were better off than they could have been or should have been."

The opposition from Montemayor, the carpenters and other former supporters was just part of the struggle facing Bass as she waged her campaign. She had consistently high disapproval numbers that stemmed from key events during her administration.

The mayor faced voter outrage over the Palisades fire, which broke out in January 2025, destroying thousands of homes and leaving 12 people dead. Residents in Pacific Palisades voiced special fury that Bass left the country days earlier, as weather forecasts predicted dangerous winds and elevated fire conditions. But she also drew the ire of Boyle Heights residents exasperated over the noxious smells that lingered in the wake of a massive fire at a cold storage warehouse.

Bass also attracted criticism over her handling of city spending — giving a series of raises to the workforce and then encountering a $1-billion shortfall, which led to the elimination of more than 1,500 vacant city jobs. One of those pay packages gave thousands of civilian city workers raises of about 24% over five years.

Then there was the mayor's fight against homelessness. Bass made it a top priority from the outset, launching an expensive program to bring people indoors. By August, 42% of the program's participants had returned to the street.

Bass declared a citywide emergency on homelessness on the day she took office, promising she would lock arms with the region's political leaders, including the L.A. County Board of Supervisors.

Two years later, over Bass' protest, the supervisors voted to pull nearly all of their money out of a joint city-county agency created to address the crisis.

Bass told The Times she was initially caught off guard by the supervisors' proposal to remove the money and funnel it into a new county homelessness department.

Leading the charge was Horvath, who had served alongside Bass on regional homelessness boards. Horvath, appearing with Raman last month, dismissed the mayor's messaging about relationship building, saying she "promised to lock arms but only demanded loyalty."

On election night, Horvath said there wasn't one specific moment when she turned against the mayor.

"I did put forward my best effort to build a relationship with the mayor. It wasn't one issue," she told The Times. "I mean, the truth is, this mayor has made clear she doesn't respect the voices and perspectives of young people."

Stuart Waldman, who heads the Los Angeles County Business Federation, offered a different take. He said Bass was good at cultivating relationships, meeting with business leaders and taking their calls. But in many instances, Bass would embrace a proposal only to have it languish in her office, he said.

"Bass would say she wanted to do something, and then it would end up in her staff's hands and never see the light of day," said Waldman, whose group supported Bass on Tuesday.

Last year, business leaders reached out to the mayor's team to express their fears that the City Council's plan to raise the minimum wage for hotel and airport workers to $30 per hour would wreak financial havoc on the city's hospitality industry.

After the council approved the increases, those business leaders responded with a ballot proposal that sought to repeal the city's business tax, which generates more than $800 million per year for city services. They used the measure as leverage to persuade the mayor and council to roll back the wage hike.

When Bass learned about the business tax repeal, she was "genuinely shocked at the depth of our frustration," said Areen Ibranossian, a political strategist who represented hotels and airlines during the talks.

"It didn't seem like she was aware of continued pleas from the business community on that issue," he said.

Worried about losing the business tax and having to make huge cuts to city services, Bass and the council struck a deal to postpone the $30 wage hike by 18 months. Although business groups were pleased with the compromise, leaders of Unite Here Local 11, the hotel workers union, were furious.

The union, which supported Bass in 2022, endorsed Raman in August.

Kurt Petersen, co-president of Unite Here Local 11, cited the minimum wage rollback as one of the reasons his union abandoned Bass.

"She signed the law that took money out of people's paychecks," he said.

Petersen said his union knocked on 20,000 doors as part of Estamos Con Nithya, a pro-Raman campaign committee set up by the carpenters union. That group was also frustrated with Bass, saying she failed to require certain labor standards for construction workers in Executive Directive 1, her initiative to fast-track the construction of affordable housing.

"There were no labor standard requirements or worker protections in Karen Bass's ED1, resulting in worker exploitation, including unpaid wages, cash pay, the use of unlicensed contractors, labor brokers and nonpayment of the L.A. city minimum wage," said Pete Rodriguez, second general vice president with the United Brotherhood of Carpenters and Joiners, in a statement.

Alex Stack, a Bass spokesperson, said the requests being made by the carpenters would have driven up the cost of affordable housing production, while also slowing down approval at City Hall. A mayor's job, he said, is to "do what's right for all of Los Angeles, not just what group backs her."

"She sat down with the Carpenters and Unite Here, listened, and made decisions that benefited L.A. — not just one particular group," Stack said. "Nobody got everything they wanted. That's what governing looks like."

Montemayor, who had worked on the pro-Bass committee in 2022, supervised the carpenters' campaign, spending nearly $12 million on efforts to promote Raman and tear down Bass. Before that, he had been Horvath's chief of staff, overseeing the supervisor's office during and after the Palisades fire.

In the wake of the disaster, tensions erupted between Horvath's office and the mayor's team. In a series of texts, Horvath and Montemayor expressed frustration with Bass' office over what they viewed as a lack of coordination and communication on the wildfire recovery efforts from City Hall.

At one point, Montemayor voiced irritation after the mayor's team announced the removal of security checkpoints on Pacific Coast Highway, then reversed course amid an outcry. "What you have done is create more chaos, not less," Montemayor wrote.

Earlier this year, hours after Raman announced her surprise campaign to unseat Bass, Montemayor posted an image from "Game of Thrones" on Instagram, one that serves as a shorthand for icy revenge: "Tell Cersei ... I want her to know it was me."

On election night, when Bass was starting to trail Raman in the vote count, Montemayor posted the meme again.

setting Season 4 haircut, the 30-year-old secrets revealed on "Pod Meets World" have become steady fodder for celebrity news websites.

The podcast is popular enough that the cast has taken it on the road. Those live shows are captured in a new documentary, "Doc Meets World," which premiered at the Tribeca Film Festival in June. The film is a testament to the cultural clout of rewatch podcasts, where cast members and creators offer revelations about their shows and about themselves.

Streaming services such as Hulu, HBO Max and Netflix have fueled the appetite for these podcasts by introducing classic shows to new audiences. For many fans, binge-watching is no longer enough. That includes younger viewers who weren't alive for a series' original run and longtime fans who want to immerse themselves in old favorites all over again.

The genre has become a staple of the podcast industry, which took in $9.2 billion in global revenue last year, according to media consulting firm Owl & Co. Some podcasts, such as "Pod Meets World" and "Off Ladies," featuring Jennifer Fischer and Angela Kinsey of "The Office," are popular enough to remain in production even after their hosts have gone through an entire library of episodes. (The hosts of both podcasts once did a crossover episode.)

Audio company iHeart Media produces more than 10 rewatch podcasts, including "Pod Meets World," "Drama Queens," hosted by Sophia Bush and other stars of the CW drama "One Tree Hill" and "A Different World From View" with Darryl M. Bell and Kadeem Hardison, an inside look at the groundbreaking sitcom "A Different World," which brought historically Black colleges and universities to television millions of prime-time viewers from 1987 to 1993.

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BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO

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FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2026



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

NITHYA RAMAN meets with supporters at the Original Farmers Market after Karen Bass conceded defeat.

Raman defeats Bass to become the next mayor of Los Angeles

Blue wave and young voters help secure the win for progressive City Council member.

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

Nithya Raman will be the next mayor of Los Angeles, making her the first challenger to defeat an incumbent L.A. mayor in more than two decades.

Mayor Karen Bass called Raman on Thursday to concede the race after the latest tally from Tuesday's election showed Raman with 52% of the vote compared with 48% for Bass, with 76% of the expected votes counted.

"Los Angeles, I'm deeply honored to be your next mayor," Raman, 45, said in a video statement. "I also wanted to pay tribute to Mayor Karen Bass, someone who has given decades of her life to making this city what it is today."

Bass, 73, thanked her supporters and said she accepted the decision of the voters.

"While this is not the outcome we hoped for, the people of Los Angeles have spoken," Bass said in a statement. "I have called Councilmember Nithya Raman to congratulate her on her victory, and I have committed to ensuring a smooth and seamless transition. Moving this city forward is what Los Angeles needs from all of us.

"Four years ago, you elected me as the first Black woman mayor in the history of Los Angeles," Bass said. "You gave me the honor of serving the city that raised me, and every single day since, I have carried that responsibility with me."

Raman's win capped off a historic sprint of a campaign. The City Council member entered the mayoral race in the final hours before the filing deadline after deciding to run the night before, going up against a onetime ally in a move that infuriated elected Democrats in L.A. who nearly unanimously supported Bass in her reelection bid.

The initial vote count after polls closed Tuesday night had Raman slightly behind Bass, but analysts saw it as a sign that Raman would win. Polls have consistently shown Raman to be heavily favored by younger, more progressive voters, who tend to turn in their ballots later than older voters.

Late-arriving mail-in ballots pushed Raman ahead, and by Thursday morning she was leading Bass by nearly 35,000 votes.

Raman and Bass were locked in a tight and contentious race up until election day, with final polling in the race showing the second-term council member

[See **Mayor**, A8]

Now the hard part: Governing

Raman will face chronic problems in the city and in city government, Steve Lopez writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

What's ahead for L.A. under a new leader

By David Zahniser, Colleen Shalby and Itzel Luna

Bike lanes. Housing vouchers. A new police chief and many more new apartments, even in single-family neighborhoods.

And above all, data to find out if City Hall programs are working.

Mayor-elect Nithya Raman won't represent a radical ideological break from her opponent, one-term incumbent Mayor Karen Bass. Like Bass, she's a Democrat who believes in ending homelessness, keeping the city safe and delivering basic services.

But Raman is expected to push the city to the left on public safety, while also advancing urbanist policies that favor public transit, greater housing production and the redesign of city streets to improve safety and support alternatives to driving.

Rick Cole, a former deputy Los Angeles mayor who advised Raman throughout the campaign, said she's dead serious about her campaign slogan "a city that works" — taking steps to ensure that streets, sidewalks and other parts of the city infrastructure are repaired, while also providing prompt responses to 911 calls.

Raman intends to be a hands-on manager, he said, improving coordination between city departments and analyzing ways to make them more effective.

"L.A. has been flying blind when it comes to measuring the impacts of the dollars spent," said Cole, a Pasadena City Council member. "That is going to change."

As mayor, Raman will have the power to hire and fire the managers of dozens of city agencies and appoint or remove hundreds of citizen commissioners — most of them volunteers — who will serve as an extension of her

[See **Agenda**, A8]

NEWSOM COMMUTES ALL STATE DEATH SENTENCES

Costs and inequity are reasons to give 548 prisoners life without parole, governor says.

BY TARYN LUNA AND SONJA SHARP

Gov. Gavin Newsom told the California Supreme Court on Thursday that he will commute the death sentences of all 548 state prisoners awaiting execution, reducing their punishments to life in prison without parole.

Newsom can commute about 40% of the death sentences with the stroke of a pen, but the rest will require the high court's approval in order to be finalized.

The mass commutation would apply to men and women convicted of some of the most heinous acts in the state's history. Newsom and other opponents of capital punishment have long argued that the process is costly, cruel and discriminatory, with death sentences disproportionately handed down to defendants of color.

"I take this action because I firmly believe that state-sanctioned killing is incompatible with California's values, undermines the foundation of our legal system, and diminishes each of us," Newsom wrote in a letter to Californians explaining his decision. "I know we cannot execute people in our imperfect legal system and remain true to our core values, first among them justice and human decency."

The move comes in Newsom's final months as governor and as he considers a run for president. Reducing the death sentences could help

Midterm results offer reset for 2028

For both parties, a shifting map requires changing strategies in race for White House.

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL, ANA CEBALLOS AND KEVIN RECTOR

WASHINGTON — Democratic upsets in this year's midterms, which stretched from the suburbs of Atlanta to rural Kansas, could reshape the electoral map that governs presidential politics — and, with it, the calculus for each party in the fight for the nation's top office in 2028.

Democrats were already cautioning against overconfidence, discussing how to translate their midterm success into more lasting power and to draw back Tuesday's voters in 2028.

For Republicans, the defeat set off something close to an existential crisis, with would-be contenders for the party's presidential nomination openly debating what had gone wrong and how the party should regroup after voters rebuked President Trump's agenda.

And members of both parties were taking stock of the deep reach Democrats demonstrated Tuesday, with Senate, House and state legislative seats flipped in red strongholds that have not been up for grabs in a presidential race

[See **Results**, A6]



TOM BRENNER Pool Photo

VICE PRESIDENT JD Vance appeared to be signaling a 2028 run by pinning blame on the Iran war.

Trump Justice official resigns

Assistant Atty. Gen. Dhillon has foisted president's agenda on civil rights office.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

Assistant Atty. Gen. Harmeet Dhillon, a California attorney who radically reshaped the Justice Department's Civil Rights Division to focus on political issues important to President Trump — including by targeting transgender rights and launching a nationwide hunt for alleged voter fraud by noncitizens — resigned her post Thursday.

In a resignation letter and in a post to X — where she routinely lambasted li-

Reservoir project clears opposition

extreme droughts and



Raman entered race late, comes out a victor

[**Mayor,** from A1]
and the incumbent mayor each with support from 40% of Angelenos while 19% of the electorate remained undecided.

But a blue wave across the country that toppled Republicans in the U.S. Senate and House of Representatives buoyed Raman's campaign against Bass from the left.

Raman ran with the backing of the Democratic Socialists of America, the leftist organization that endorsed Mayor Zohran Mamdani in New York and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-N.Y.), among others.

Bass, meanwhile, ran on a public safety message that was meant to convince moderates and more conservative voters that she was a better alternative to Raman.

The election was, first and foremost, a generational shift, as Raman swept the youth vote throughout the city and Bass performed better with voters older than 50.

"I look at this race almost completely through a generational lens," said Dan Schnur, a professor of politics at USC, Pepperdine and UC Berkeley.

"I think this is a new coalition built by Nithya Raman based on age," said Mike Trujillo, a Democratic consultant who supported Bass in the race. "This is not a geographic coalition or racial coalition, this is a when-you-were-born coalition."

The last challenger to defeat an incumbent mayor was then-City Councilmember Antonio Villaraigosa, who defeated James K. Hahn in 2005.

None of Raman's colleagues on the City Council endorsed her bid for mayor. Raman said she wasn't bothered by the lack of support, casting herself instead as a hopeful technocrat who wanted to deliver "A City That Works," her campaign slogan, promising to make L.A. a city that fixes broken sidewalks and potholes and repairs streetlights in a more timely manner.

"This city's government has made solving problems look impossible for so long that I heard from people across this city who started to believe it was impossible," Raman said in an election night speech to hundreds of raucous supporters at the Greek Theatre plaza in Griffith Park. "Hopelessness can be fatal for a city, but this campaign refused to accept that."



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

NITHYA RAMAN hugs her brother, Akash, at her election night party at the Greek Theatre plaza. Her term as mayor will begin Dec. 8.

Although Raman didn't declare victory on Tuesday, her speech had all the markings of someone who expected to win.

"In just one century, Los Angeles built itself into a global metropolis," she said. "The gateway to the Pacific. A center of ingenuity and invention. The cultural capital of the entire planet. That ambitious Los Angeles, that joyful Los Angeles, that creative Los Angeles, that entrepreneurial Los Angeles, that inclusive Los Angeles is the Los Angeles that this campaign was born to fight for."

Raman's term as mayor will begin Dec. 8, and the job pays $310,000 a year. The City Council is expected to schedule a special election to fill her vacancy on the council, where she represented a Hollywood Hills-centered district.

Raman's status as mayor-elect would have seemed nearly unthinkable at the start of the year, when Bass' challengers included former reality TV star Spencer Pratt, former L.A. Unified Supt. Austin Beutner, leftist the Rev. Rae Huang and entrepreneur Adam Miller — with L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath and billionaire developer Rick Caruso also considering bids.

Beutner suspended his bid after the death of his daughter, and it seemed Bass, despite low approval ratings, might glide to a second term without a serious challenger in the race.

But the night before the filing deadline on Feb. 7, rumors began swirling that Raman was considering challenging Bass.

"She saw the lane open before anybody else. Then she got in. Once she explained to me what the lane was, I was like, she can absolutely win," said Adam Conover, an actor and writer who volunteered on Raman's campaign for mayor.

Conover explained there was a lane for a progressive pragmatist who could capitalize on voter frustration with the status quo — similar to how Raman first won her council seat in 2020, when she unseated incumbent David Ryu.

The day after Raman announced her run, Conover and others were in Raman's backyard ADU helping set up the campaign.

"Who remembers in February when it was the end of the candidate filing and no one was, like, running for mayor?" asked City Controller Kenneth Mejia at Raman's election night party. "I was like, 'Oh my God, I'm going to be here again for another four years stuck like this.'

"And then out of nowhere — out of nowhere — Nithya Raman came out of nowhere with the three-pointer and she came out of nowhere and was like, 'I'm running for mayor!' " Mejia yelled during a rollicking speech as he mimed himself shooting a basketball.

After her speech, Raman asked her supporters to join her on the dance floor, where she shimmied to "Remember the Time" by Michael Jackson, pausing every few moments to hug her backers and pose for selfies.

"People want change. They are not happy with what the last four years have brought," Horvath said at Raman's election night party. "They didn't want to rubber-stamp another term of it. Councilmember Raman stepped up with courage and grace to take on the status quo. It's never easy."

"It doesn't always win you friends," Horvath added, "but she did it."

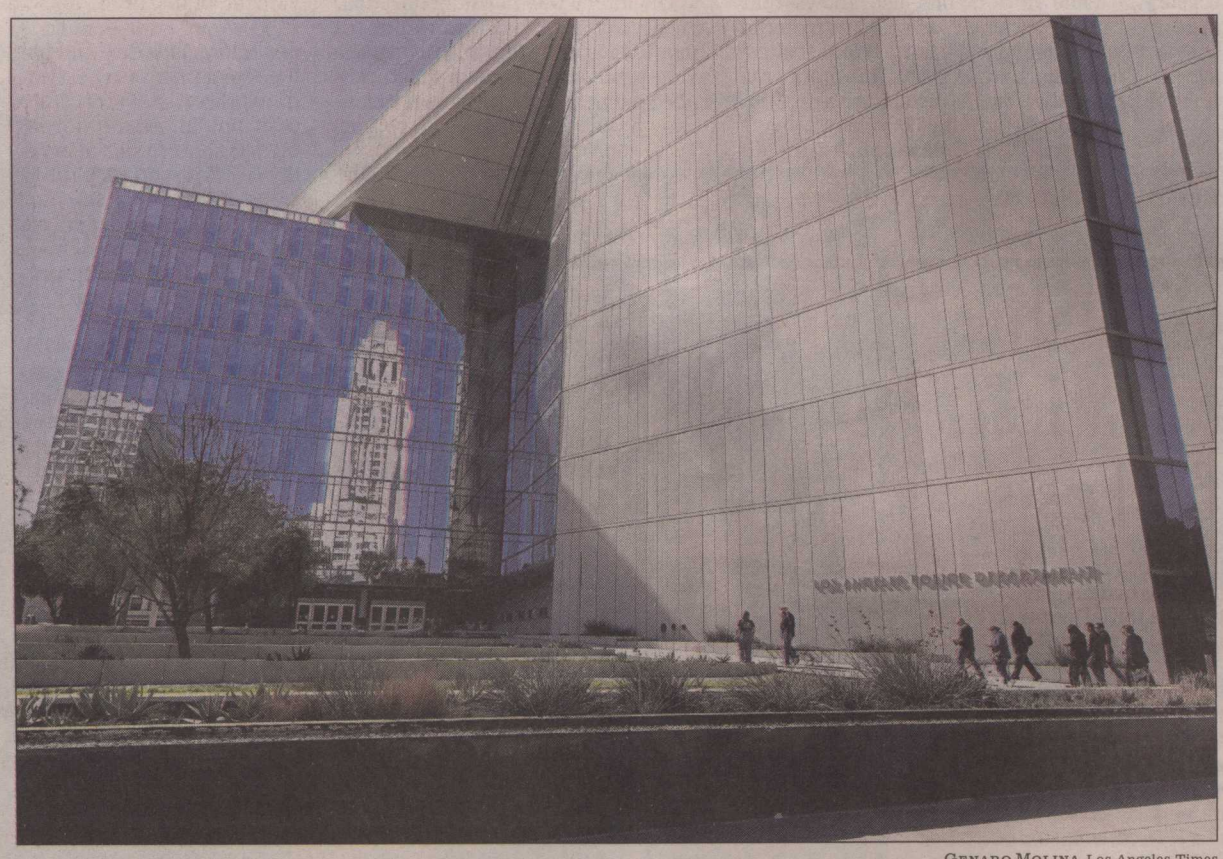
How Raman might make L.A. 'a city that works'

[**Agenda,** from A1]
administration.

Cole is widely expected to supervise Raman's transition team, sharing those duties with Andrea Conant, chief of staff for Raman's council office. The mayor-elect will also have a close ally in City Controller Kenneth Mejia, the only elected official at City Hall to endorse her.

On the campaign trail, Raman has promised to let Mejia audit every dollar of city spending on homelessness, setting the stage for a potential overhaul of L.A.'s approach to the crisis. She said she would let his teams of investigators monitor encampment cleanups and operations aimed at moving homeless people indoors, something Bass resisted.

Raman has described the city's use of hotel and motel rooms for temporary housing as expensive and ineffective, saying short-term rental vouchers are a better alternative. She has vowed to cut homelessness in half by the 2028 Olympic Games and entirely by the end of her



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

CITY HALL is reflected on the windows of the Police Department headquarters in downtown Los Angeles.

All, best known for its success in 2024 in passing Measure HLA, which requires the expansion of bus lanes, bike lanes and other street improvements during major road repairs.

Michael Schneider, who heads that group, said he believes Raman will consolidate some of the city departments that are responsible for street maintenance, to make them more effective. He said it's also likely she will pursue a ballot measure in 2028 — possibly a bond or tax hike — to raise money for sidewalk repairs, curb replacements, wheelchair ramps and other improvements.

Schneider predicted that Raman also will go much further than former Mayor Eric Garcetti, another transit enthusiast, on such issues as bike lanes, making tough decisions "even though it's hard."

"It doesn't mean she's going to railroad everything," he said. "But I think she has much more of a political spine than Garcetti did when it comes to street safety, pushing projects through

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BY JOHN AINGER

In Dubai three
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Los Angeles Times
latimes.com
6 DESIGNATED AREAS HIGHER © 2026
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2026

A generational remake' from the left

AMAN S POISED O WIN, NALYSTS REDICT

BY NOAH GOLDBERG, OAH HAGGERTY ND CLARA HARTER

A jubilant Nithya Raman ood before cheering sup-orters at her election night arty Tuesday, giving a peech that fell just shy of eclaring victory, but one hat urged the crowd at the reek Theatre plaza to hold ff on the celebrations for ow.

"I'm hopeful. I'm very opeful," Raman told a rau-ous crowd fueled by tequila nd chicken tenders. "I'm lso really superstitious. So e're all just going to be cool, K? Very cool."

The initial vote tally uesday had Raman ightly behind incumbent aren Bass in the race for os Angeles mayor, but ana-sts were quick to point out hat this was actually a trong indication that Ra-an would win. Polls have consistently shown Raman s heavily favored by younger oters, who tend to vote later than older people and whose late-arriving ballots are con-sidered likely to turn the tide in her favor.

"The expectation is that once Nithya Raman starts gaining votes she will contin-ue to gain votes. There is not going to be a seesaw. It is likely going to be pretty uni-directional," said Paul Mitchell, who heads the polling data firm PDI. "I don't call races. But if that expectation holds true, then there is no reason to expect that Raman is going to do anything but gain votes from here."

Votes were still being counted the day after the election, but by early Wednesday morning, Raman had taken a slight lead over Bass. She grew that lead by a percentage point Wednesday afternoon as more ballots were counted, with about 52% of the vote compared with Bass' 48%. Raman is now up by more than 25,000 votes.

"Nithya Raman is going to win. She's going to be our next mayor," said a gleeful L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath, who has clashed with Bass and en-dorsed Raman a few weeks before the election.

"It's over," declared Este-van Montemayor, who ran an independent expenditure group supporting Raman.

Across town at the Loews Hollywood Hotel, Bass proj-ected confidence on Tues-

[See Raman, A9]



CHIP SOMODEVILLA Getty Images

SUPPORTERS of Democratic Sen.-elect James Talarico celebrate as they watch election returns in Texas.

Democrats' historic triumph was fueled by a rare coalition of voters.

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Democrats heralded a new era in American politics Wednesday after voters broke Republicans' control of government and delivered a pivotal rebuke of President Trump.

Victories that handed Democrats control of the House and Senate on Tues-day night came in historic form, with margins outstrip-ping expectations and dou-ble-digit shifts to the left by nearly every voting bloc. In some of the reddest states in the union, even Republican redistricting efforts de-signed to shield districts from competition were not enough to prevent Demo-cratic inroads.

The sweeping wins were driven by a rare coalition of voters across nearly all walks of American life, in cit-ies and countryside, from the rural Midwest and Deep South to a traditionally con-servative mid-Atlantic. Not since voters were repulsed by President Nixon after the Watergate scandal half a century ago has the popular vote swung so decisively in a single election cycle.

The wave was so compre-hensive that it handed Democrats wins that for decades had been unthink-able — flipping Senate seats in Kansas, South Carolina and Texas — and a majority of governors' seats for the

[See Democrats, A6]

What will define the 'Becerra era'?

BY NICOLE NIXON

California is about to en-ter the "Becerra era," though the governor-elect who coined that phrase has dropped few hints about what will define it.

After a decisive Tuesday night victory in the race to succeed termed-out Gov. Gavin Newsom, Xavier Be-cerra will take the helm with a slate of potential economic opportunities: luring back Hollywood production, drawing international visi-tors to the 2028 Olympic Games, implementing vot-er-approved housing bonds and responsibly growing the artificial intelligence indus-try.

But a long list of chal-lenges awaits: grappling with worst-in-the-nation unemployment, solving the housing crisis, and prepar-ing for and responding to seemingly endless fires, floods and other natural di-sasters.



ANDRI TAMBUNAN For The Times

CALIFORNIA Gov.-elect Xavier Becerra grasps supporters' hands during an election night party.

The optimistic 68-year-old told supporters gath-ered for his campaign party in West Sacramento that his mission is to "deliver a Cali-fornia we can afford and de-fend a California we can't af-ford to lose."

"Here's the good news," Becerra, a Democrat, told the packed and cheering crowd. "Californians don't expect a miracle from gov-ernment; they just want gov-ernment that works. A gov-ernment that can build things. A government that keeps our streets clean and schools safe. Basic services delivered on time and on budget."

Easier said than done.

[See Becerra, A10]

ELECTION 2026

Totals as of 4:30 p.m. Wednesday

LOS ANGELES MAYOR



Nithya Raman (D)
51.7%

Karen Bass (D)
48.3%
Estimated 66.6% of vote in

STATEWIDE MEASURES

Proposition 40
No
55.3%
Yes
44.7%
Estimated 60.9% of vote in

Proposition 39
✓ No
58.9%
Yes
41.1%
Estimated 60.8% of vote in

CALIFORNIA GOVERNOR



✓ Xavier Becerra (D)
64.2%

Steve Hilton (R)
35.8%
Estimated 60.6% of vote in

120TH CONGRESS

House of Representatives
218 seats needed to control the House

Democrats	Republicans	Uncalled
237	147	51

Senate
51 seats needed to control the Senate

Democrats	Republicans	Uncalled
54	44	2

On the web: Vote counts update periodically as results are reported by the Associated Press and the county registrars. Find our most up-to-date results at *latimes.com*.

New focus on reining in Trump and prices

BY ANA CEBALLOS AND JUSTINE MCDANIEL

WASHINGTON — Democrats in Congress gained the power Tuesday night to more forcefully in-vestigate President Trump and rein in his agenda, set-ting up confrontations that are likely to define the final two years of his presidency.

As party leaders on Wednesday celebrated re-taking the House and Sen-ate, they vowed to put Trump and his administra-tion on the defensive with subpoenas and hearings, a role that voters made clear they want them to play. But they also said the top pri-ority would be the issue that swept them to power: mak-ing life more affordable.

"We are going to work hard to drive costs down with the president or with-out him, period," Sen. Chuck Schumer, who is poised to become Senate majority

Why the billionaire tax fell short in California

MORE ELECTION COVERAGE INSIDE

Interference: Feared disruption by federal agents doesn't

Latino voters helped secure blue victories

SCIENCE



NASA

THE SWIFT Observatory, shown at Cape Canaveral, Fla., in 2002, discovered thousands of cosmic explosions.

NASA's Swift telescope plunges back to Earth after 22-year orbit

Fiery reentry follows a failed rescue of the observatory months earlier

By Marcia Dunn

CAPE CANAVERAL, Fla. — An aging NASA telescope reentered Earth's atmosphere Wednesday after a failed rescue effort in the summer left it tottering lower and lower, the U.S. Space Force confirmed.

Most of the 1½-ton Swift Observatory was expected to burn up in the atmosphere. But a few pieces made of denser-than-lead tungsten and some mirror parts could have survived reentry, according to NASA.

NASA and the Space Force did not immediately confirm whether any components have survived.

Reentry occurred over northern Sumatra, Indonesia, at 4:39 a.m. Pacific time, according to the Space Force, which tracked the telescope's dwindling path.

Its cosmic cremation has the Swift team mourning, yet full of gratitude for the observations the telescope made during its 22 years in orbit. Swift blasted off on Nov. 20, 2004, to search for some of the biggest explosions in the universe: gamma-ray bursts and supernovas.

"We've known this day would come since before Swift was launched. At least in low-Earth orbit, what goes up must come down. And that end is catastrophic," said Pennsylvania State University's John Nousek, an astronomer who led the control team.

Intense solar activity over the last few years dragged Swift down faster than usual. NASA hired Katalyst Space a year ago to mount a rush rescue. But the company's three-armed robot named Link ran into trouble after launching in July and got no closer than seven to nine miles from Swift. Link plunged back to Earth in September.

Swift resumed observations once the rescue attempt was called off, discovering even more gamma-ray bursts and other ultrahigh-energy events. But by late October, the telescope was too low to remain steady for observations, and its systems were shut down.

Its final tally: more than 2,000 gamma-ray bursts and 1,400 exploding stars, not to mention a slew of comets, asteroids and star-shredding black holes. The telescope's superpower was its ability to swivel swiftly — thus its name — toward erupting celestial events.

NASA considered Swift a first responder for the Hubble and Webb space telescopes and others that would follow its alerts and provide deeper investigations. Scientists are still figuring out how to fill the gap.

"Our fervent hope is that the lessons learned by the successes of Swift can be applied to new generations of space missions to accelerate our discoveries about the universe," Nousek said in an email.

Dunn writes for the Associated Press. Times staff writer Noah Haggerty contributed to this report.

Wash. resident dies from bird flu

The person was exposed to infected cattle. It's the first such death in a year.

By Mike Stobbe

NEW YORK — A person in Washington state has died from complications of bird flu, the first such U.S. death in a year.

The Yakima County resident, who had previous health conditions, was exposed to avian influenza at a dairy with infected cattle and had been hospitalized.

Two other U.S. deaths have been tied to bird flu since it became a national public health concern in 2024. The first, announced in January 2025, was an elderly person in Louisiana who had a version of bird flu known as H5N1. The other, in Washington state, died in November 2025 from a rarer version called H5N5.

Yakima County officials did not release any additional details about the person who recently died. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention said the person was infected with H5N1.

County officials have reported that 33 dairy herds recently have tested positive for H5N1.

They said that three human infections have been linked to exposure at a dairy, and that the Yakima Health District is working with state health department find people who were in contact with those peo and monitor them for sy toms.

The H5N1 bird flu been spreading wid among wild birds, poul cows and other animals several years. Health c cerns escalated in early 2 when infections spr among U.S. livestock. presence in the environm increases the chances t people will be exposed a potentially sickened, o cials have said.

More than 70 human fections have been report in the U.S. since the beg ning of 2024, according to CDC. But there is no know person-to-person sprea and the risk to the gener public is low, the agen said.

The agency analyzed th genetic sequence of the vir from the person who died Washington and found changes that would ma the virus spread more easil or cause more severe illness a CDC spokesperson said.

Officials continue to urg people who have contac with sick or dead birds t take precautions, includin wearing respiratory and ey protection and gloves whe handling poultry. Peopl who work on farms are con sidered to be at higher risk.

Stobbe writes for the Associated Press.

Bayer seeking to edit DNA of major grains to use less fertilizer

By Sonja Wind

Bayer AG is looking to develop gene-edited grains capable of tapping nitrogen from the air, potentially reducing the need for costly fertilizers after the Middle East war has exposed the vulnerability of supplies.

The German pharmaceutical and crop science giant has obtained a commercial license for a technology developed at UC Davis, a leading center for genetic research.

The approach involves editing the DNA of grain crops so their roots can form relationships with soil bacteria that turn nitrogen from the air into a form the plants can use.

Researchers have spent decades trying to develop grains that can grow with less synthetic fertilizer, which underpins roughly half of global food production but is also a major source of greenhouse gas emissions.

The effort has taken on added urgency as supply disruptions linked to the United States' war on Iran have sent fertilizer prices soaring, exposing farmers and food-producing nations to the risks of relying on imports from a relatively small group of suppliers.

"It's game-changing because we are able to unlock the possibilities in crops



Dan Kitwood Getty Images

MILLING wheat is harvested in August for Waddenhall Farm in Petham, England.

ade. It could also help Bayer capture a slice of the $85-billion market for urea, a type of nitrogen fertilizer, Berninger said, adding that the European Union still gets nearly a quarter of such imports from Russia.

Earlier this year, EU lawmakers voted in favor of a framework for gene-edited plants in the bloc, clearing the final hurdle for legislation to enable the cultivation of hardier crops.

"The beauty is also with the European regulation now being much more welcoming for gene editing that this allows us to introduce a platform for three crops the world depends on to become less dependent on fertilizer," Berninger said, adding that fertilizer is "by far" the highest cost for far-

Fresh guidance on menopause meds

By Laura Ungar



Associated Press

A PATCH that delivers estrogen through the skin.

For the first time in a dozen years, a leading OB-GYN group has updated its guidance on managing hot flashes, night sweats, sleep changes and other disruptive symptoms that often come with menopause.

Doctors stressed the importance of hormone therapies, which many women are considering again after the removal of federal safety warnings. Federal officials said the Food and Drug Administration has been taking steps to ensure there's an adequate supply.

Doctors also described various nonhormonal options in the new advice released last month by the American College of Obstetricians & Gynecologists.

"We would love our patients to go to their OB-GYNs regarding questions about menopause and really advocate for getting the treatment that they need," said Dr. Camille Clare, the group's president.

ical School. "This should help to empower women to discuss their symptoms with their healthcare provider."

Hormone therapy works for many

Manson said ACOG's new guidelines are similar to those put out by other medical organizations.

"Moderate to severe or bothersome menopausal symptoms should be treated with hormone therapy as the first line of treatment," she said. Although it's not

warning has helped revive interest in and demand for the treatments.

Since the FDA labeling change, some women have reported difficulty obtaining estrogen patches in certain doses and formulations.

FDA officials said Friday that despite such reports, they are unaware of "an imminent risk of a nationwide shortage." Officials also noted that drug manufacturers have doubled their output of the products over the last year by adding extra manufacturing shifts and

tients, and take into account the benefits and risks given a patient's age and medical history. If it's appropriate, the group advises starting it before age 60, or within 10 years of menopause.

Other options for hot flashes

Some patients choose not to take full-body hormonal medications or are advised by their doctors to avoid them because of their medical histories or conditions. For them, doctors pointed to different medicines. One is fezolinetant, which works in the area of the brain that controls body temperature and blocks a source of hot flashes and night sweats. Another is elinzanetant, which works similarly.

Doctors also said certain antidepressants can help manage symptoms like hot flashes and depression in patients with either or both of these problems.

There's also evidence supporting some non-drug

What the el

By Laurence Darmiento, Nilesh Christopher and Caroline Petrow-Cohen

The historic landslide victory for Democrats in the midterm elections deeply bruised the Republican Party and President Trump, but there's one man who may have been hurt equally as bad: Elon Musk, the world's richest person and the party's biggest donor.

The near trillionaire reportedly spent close to $450 million backing GOP candidates across the country and in Texas specifically — where his SpaceX and Tesla are headquartered and have large operations — but his massive donations failed spectacularly and may have backfired.

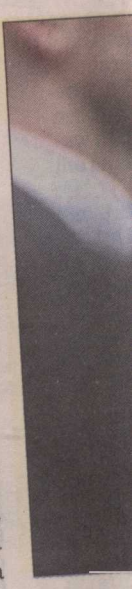
Now Musk and his businesses could face a challenging time ahead as Democrats are expected to rein in the unfettered growth of AI businesses and likely expose him and his companies in particular to more congressional and regulatory scrutiny.

"Top of the Democratic agenda on day 1 needs to be a pause on advanced AI development, regulation of this out of control industry, and a ban on artificial superintelligence," Rep. Yassamin Ansari (D-Ariz.), wrote on X.

With Democrats taking control of House and Senate committees, Musk also faces the possibility of being called before Congress to answer questions about his controversial role leading DOGE, or the so-called Department of Government Efficiency.

Even Musk quipped on X about the results: "Guess my election-interfering space lasers didn't work this time."

A representative for Musk could not be reached for comment.



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New Culver

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Development known as ElevenOneEleven comes as officials call for more housing.

By Roger Vincent

Construction has begun on a $200-million apartment complex in Culver City at a time when housing development in much of Los Angeles County has slowed in spite of strong demand.

The earth is being graded at the busy intersection of Jefferson and Sepulveda boulevards to make way for the development of 344 units over street-level retail businesses in a complex called ElevenOneEleven, which will include two public parks.

Building the project are developers Lincoln Property Co. of Dallas and New York-based McCourt Partners. Lincoln was one of the major developers of the nearby community of Playa Vista that was built in recent decades on the site of the former headquarters of Hughes Air-

After fight

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Los Angeles Times

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Feds deploy election watchers to L.A.

The late surge adds to turmoil over voting as Justice Department presses its case.

By Sonja Sharp

The Justice Department sent a last-minute surge of election monitors into Los Angeles on Tuesday morning, amid an ongoing legal tug-of-war over California's 20,000 contested ballots.

In a series of rulings late Monday night and early Tuesday, the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals cleared the Trump administration to threaten California election workers with criminal charges, even after its demands to segregate contested ballots were struck down by the Supreme Court.

The appellate court's final decision came on election day, just after the Justice Department announced it was sending out "1,000 election monitors and observers" across the U.S. in what it called "the largest monitoring effort in DOJ history."

Los Angeles, New York, Chicago and Detroit were among the dozens of jurisdictions where monitors were sent under the auspices of the Voting Rights Act of 1965 — legislation that President Trump has worked tirelessly to gut across both his administrations.

The Justice Department said it also would send monitors to San Diego, Sacramento and Alameda County in the San Francisco Bay Area. A department spokesperson said that the federal monitors "will be at polling locations," but that the department is not "giving out precinct details."

The move was widely seen as an intimidation tactic.

[See **Monitors,** A6]





Photographs by Genaro Molina Los Angeles Times

WORTH THE WAIT

People cast their ballots at Grand Central Market, top, in downtown Los Angeles on Tuesday. At USC, voters waited more than an hour. Scan this code to read our coverage at latimes.com and in our eNewspaper, where subscribers get an exclusive "LATExtra."

Little room for error for the next mayor of L.A.

Whoever is elected faces slew of problems, including on budget, police and housing.

By Jenny Jarvie

Homeless encampments line the streets. Buying a home — or even finding an affordable place to rent — is increasingly out of reach for many. Roads are riddled with potholes, tens of thousands of streetlights are out, and water and power bills are surging.

For many Angelenos, quality of life in the city is slipping.

These challenges have left some longtime political experts wondering how much the next mayor can control in this vast city of 3.8 million.

"The expectations, given the powers that the mayor actually has, are probably too high," said Tom Hogen-Esch, a professor of political science at Cal State Northridge. "You have all of these wicked problems that are difficult to solve in a perfect scenario, and [even more] in a governmental system as tangled and confused as L.A."

Along with the enduring problems of deteriorating infrastructure, police reform and budget woes, there is also the unprecedented task of rebuilding Pacific Palisades after catastrophic firestorms and trying to help the city's ailing film industry — all while preparing the city for the global spotlight of hosting the 2028 Olympics.

A recent UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies poll of likely L.A. voters, co-sponsored by The Times, found that the top priority for the next mayor to address was reducing the number of homeless encampments, followed by ensuring public safety and building more affordable housing. Protecting immigrant communities was the next most cited concern, followed by balancing the city budget.

After studying L.A. politics for more than three decades, Hogen-Esch said the city feels stuck.

"We're talking about the same issues over and over and over ... and a general underlying frustration with city government," he said. "It's almost like you could wake up 30 years later in a Rip Van Winkle dream and you're in the same spot."

Homelessness

When Karen Bass launched her 2021 mayoral campaign, she proclaimed homelessness was her "overwhelming top priority."

After nearly four years of her leadership, she has failed to make a serious dent on homelessness. This year, the Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority announced that more than 45,194 people in the city were homeless — not significantly different from 46,260 homeless people in January 2023.

After spending more than $391 million on Inside Safe, Bass' flagship program to clean up homeless encampments and house homeless people, the city moved about 6,500 people into interim housing. But about 42% of the program's participants have returned to homelessness.

Bass says Inside Safe has made progress, clearing 140 encampments across the city. But the difference is not visible to many residents as encampments continue to

[See **Mayor,** A6]

Real work awaits Democrats in state

Party maintains its grip on California but will have to deal with its chronic problems.

By Jenny Jarvie

For all their dominance, California Democrats will emerge from Tuesday's election facing a list of considerable difficulties.

As polls show nearly 6 out of 10 Californians believe the state is going in the wrong direction and even more anticipate bad financial times ahead, the state's new governor and legislators will have to confront some chronic problems, including a severe budget deficit, housing unaffordability, homelessness, and rising energy and insurance costs.

They will also have to grapple with difficult decisions on whether the state can provide Medi-Cal healthcare to low-income residents, how to make the state more resilient to climate change, and who pays for wildfire damage.

"There's not going to be a long honeymoon period," said Mark Baldassare, the survey director at the nonpartisan Public Policy Institute of California.

Californians are in a "pretty grumpy mood," Baldassare said. Although their dissatisfaction is mostly hyperpartisan, with Democrats pointing the finger at President Trump and Congress as Republicans blame Gov. Gavin Newsom and Sacramento legislators, he said, a majority of Californians are worried about the state of the economy and want to see better government performance.

For voters, a key concern is unaffordability. More than half of Californians rank cost of living, inflation and the economy — along with hous-

[See **Democrats,** A7]

Specter of new fighting grips Mideast

Mixed U.S. signals on Iran war stoke fears of more dangerous, more destructive escalation.

By Nabih Bulos

MANAMA, Bahrain — Conferences in the Persian Gulf are usually positive affairs, with government officials, executives of state-owned companies and armies of consultants touting petro-fueled visions promising fantastical technology and prosperity.

Yet optimism seemed in short supply at the Manama Dialogue, an annual security and geopolitical summit held in the Bahraini capital. Instead, the dominant mood among the Middle East diplomats, defense officials and experts assembled last weekend was fear over the consequences of another bout of U.S.-Iran fighting.

"The rules of logic tell us that the Iranian stand and the American stand are far apart. And if these positions are not bridged, then we have to worry about the worst," Anwar Gargash, a presidential advisor in the United Arab Emirates, said in an address at the summit.

Gargash added that it's not in the interest of the regional countries or Iran to go through another round of war.

"While we're going through this period of protracted crisis of no war, no peace, we are clearly seeking a political off-ramp," he said.

In his address, Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty said, "We have to push very hard in order to prevent the escalation."

Noting that more fighting would affect food and energy security, he added, "The second round will be more

[See **Mideast,** A4]

$4 billion in Israel aid to be cut off

Trump says the annual monetary support is superfluous and a boon for Democrats. **WORLD, A2**

Utilities lobby for wildfire cost shield

California's power companies seek legislation to protect their shareholders.

By Melody Petersen

As a criminal investigation into Southern California Edison's actions before last year's deadly Eaton fire continues, the state's for-profit utilities are lobbying for legislation that would protect their shareholders from paying for future catastrophic fires they cause.

According to slides recently presented by a Pacific

to pay the lion's share for fires utilities cause, there is no imperative for the for-profit utilities to take safety and fire mitigation seriously," said Jamie Court, president of Consumer Watchdog.

The utilities say their shareholders must be shielded from wildfire costs because the risk of future fires has damaged their credit ratings. Lower credit ratings mean the companies must pay higher interest rates on borrowing, an increased cost that gets passed on to electricity customers.

"It is in our customers' interest to have action in

A pitfall of new ADUs: Loss of parking